Jonathan Rhodes, Jaime Blakeley-Glover, Andy Miller and Alan Taylor

Chapter 9
Measuring and training Inner Development Goals: Developing inner drivers for achieving sustainability goals

Abstract: Organizations worldwide are pledging ambitious climate action, but translating these commitments into meaningful progress remains a significant challenge. This chapter introduces an approach focused on Inner Development Goals (IDGs) – measuring and training the critical inner capacities that enable individuals to become effective agents of environmental change within their own lives and within organizations. Through an insightful narrative, the chapter chronicles the journey of developing the Inner Development Goals – Adapted (IDG-A) scale to rigorously assess 29 personal skills, qualities, and mindsets across six key dimensions: self-awareness, cognitive skills, caring for others and the world, social skills, driving change, and feelings of organizational belonging. Research validates the IDG-A in evaluating employees' readiness for climate action. Moreover, the chapter presents the meaning, awareness, and purpose (MAP) model – an experiential coaching process designed to activate teams by connecting them deeply to the meaning behind sustainability efforts, fostering collective awareness, instilling a shared sense of purpose, and translating their inner work into consistent outward impact. Findings show the MAP model's benefits in elevating IDG-A scores and catalyzing measurable climate initiatives compared to conventional training approaches. When focusing on human inner drivers as the catalyst for organizational outer change, this chapter offers a framework for addressing a critical impediment: the intrinsic motivation required from employees to fully embrace their role in achieving an organization's environmental goals.

Keywords: climate change, sustainability, Inner Development Goals, organizational change, MAP

Introduction

As the reality of climate change becomes increasingly dire, organizations around the world are under immense pressure to take substantive action. Ambitious sustainability goals and public commitments to reduce carbon footprints and achieve net-zero emissions are becoming the norm. However, a critical gap remains: successfully translating these laudable pledges into meaningful behavioral changes and progress on the ground that breaks the inertia of business as usual.

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Despite having the technical knowledge, resources, and strategic plans in place, a report by Accenture (2022) found that 93% of companies struggle to inspire their employees to fully embrace and drive climate initiatives forward with consistent effort. A fundamental disconnect exists between the high-level goals set by leadership and the intrinsic motivation required from individual employees to proactively adapt their mindsets and behaviors in service of those goals.

This chapter explores an innovative approach aimed at bridging this divide between intention and action on climate change within organizations. Focusing on the concept of Inner Development Goals (IDGs) and rigorously measuring the personal skills, qualities, and mindsets required for individuals to become effective agents of environmental change. This work equips organizations and coaches working to support businesses, with powerful tools to motivate and activate their workforces.

Through rich narratives, empirical research findings, and the development of novel assessment frameworks like the Inner Development Goals – Adapted (IDG-A) scale, this chapter focuses on a human-centric pathway towards developing the intrinsic motivation, self-awareness, and sense of purpose necessary for employees to fully commit to their organization's sustainability efforts.

Motivation

Sarah Miller was no ordinary British professional. She grew up in a working-class family in the southwest of England, and despite humble beginnings, she excelled academically and became the first member of her family to go to university. After graduating with first-class honors, Sarah began her corporate career in the finance industry in London. Her meteoric rise was fueled by a relentless work ethic, analytical brilliance, and unwavering determination to succeed – traits that were somewhat unconventional for a young woman in the male-dominated finance world at the time.

Sarah's journey through the corporate trenches included pivotal roles as a data analyst at two prominent insurance firms and later at a hedge fund. In these capacities, she emerged as the linchpin for the financial growth and success of these businesses. If we were to liken those organizations to a basketball team, they would undoubtedly have been the '96 Chicago Bulls, with Sarah standing as the Michael Jordan of the corporate court. She not only led but also inspired, worked tirelessly, and consistently demanded and delivered results.

Yet, as the narrative of every great individual within a world-class team unfolds, there comes a juncture when a new direction beckons; a choice point, and the pursuit of a fresh challenge becomes inevitable.

Sarah's quest for a new challenge led her to identify the most formidable role within her current finance organization: environmental, social, and governance (ESG) leadership. The mere contemplation of this ambitious undertaking amplified a crea-

tive fire within her, culminating in a meticulously crafted pitch after 16 hours of dedicated effort. The result? A ground-breaking role as the head of thought leadership and net-zero.

Undeterred by the inherent challenges, Sarah orchestrated an informal conversation with the ever-busy chief executive officer (CEO), strategically planting the seeds of this novel role over a cup of coffee. Three days later, a new chapter unfolded as Sarah assumed her position, tasked with shaping a team poised to undertake a challenging net-zero goal.

Her first order of business? A pragmatic dive into the realm of data. Armed with an arsenal of spreadsheets, Sarah immersed herself in a comprehensive fact-finding mission. Reports, academic papers, and government policies became her literary companions, while conferences provided dynamic classrooms for gaining insights into the complex struggles of ESG within the industry. With each endeavor, she enriched her expanding datasheets with best practices, navigating the terrain with strategic finesse.

Over the initial months, Sarah not only discovered what worked but also gained profound insights into the less traveled paths that proved less effective. As her understanding of the sustainability impacts of the finance industry grew, so did her education. She looked beyond conventional boundaries, encompassing United Nations initiatives, global directives, government projects, organizational pledges, and ambitious targets. Fueled by this wealth of knowledge and her eye for detail, she felt equipped with the requisite skills and tools to enlighten others on the path to achieving net-zero targets.

The culmination of her efforts occurred six months into her role when the executive team, on this occasion led by Sarah, made their climate pledge public – a commitment to work towards three scopes, and achieve net-zero by 2030. The seeds of change had sprouted, and Sarah found herself at the forefront of a collective endeavor towards a sustainable future.

Drawing upon her comprehensive assessment of the company's carbon footprint, Sarah charted a course toward the ambitious goal of achieving net-zero. The objectives, as meticulously outlined, appeared not only feasible but grounded in a pragmatic approach: localize supply chains where possible, curtail energy consumption (particularly in business travel), enforce waste reduction measures, and elevate employee awareness regarding sustainability practices. With a specific goal and a meticulously detailed plan, Sarah set the stage for an organizational change. However, amidst the precision of her strategies and the clarity of her objectives, there lingered a factor that had eluded Sarah's initial considerations: human motivation.

In this dynamic equation of corporate evolution, the variable of human behavior emerged as an unforeseen challenge. The attitudes, perceptions, and the inertia of routine posed a barrier, one that was not captured on spreadsheets and strategic plans. It was a realization that prompted Sarah to reevaluate her approach and seek solutions that would bridge the gap between intention and action.

To Sarah's astonishment, an intriguing paradox unfolded within the organization. Despite being well-versed in the various avenues leading to the net-zero target, employees exhibited a surprising ambivalence toward altering their existing behaviors. A disconnect from the net-zero goal presented itself, and a sense of stagnation permeated the workplace, as if the gears of change were rusted in place. It was not merely a matter of awareness; it was a poignant realization that a personal connection to the overarching goal was lacking.

The workforce, it seemed, was entangled in the vines of habitual routines, exhibiting a resistance to change that mirrored an unwillingness to untangle from the familiar. More than just a lack of motivation, there was a conspicuous absence of the skills and qualities required to activate both themselves and their peers. The workplace had become an environment of inertia, a paradox where knowledge coexisted with a resistance to change.

Puzzled by this apparent motivational vacuum, Sarah assumed the role of an organizational detective, driven by an unwavering determination to decipher this enigma. It was a challenge that resonated with her go-getter spirit, prompting her to embark on a search for a solution that would untangle the knots of complacency and set the stage for a harmonious convergence of intention and action.

Developing a research team and shaping the project

While Sarah Miller delved into the labyrinth of motivational challenges, a parallel convergence of minds was underway in the digital realm: over a hundred executive coaches, business executives, psychologists, and researchers, all committed to the cause of climate change, gathered in a virtual rendezvous hosted by the Climate Coaching Alliance (CCA). The focal point of this virtual gathering was nothing less than ambitious: activating teams for climate change.

After the formalities and initial introductions, conversations evolved and shifted as participants seamlessly transitioned into breakout rooms, each dedicated to delving into specific areas of the overarching theme. Picture 48 Zoom windows illuminating Breakout Room 3, under the able chairmanship of Dr Alyson Whybrow, a founding member of the CCA and an accomplished executive coach. The spotlight of this particular breakout room was fixed on the intriguing domain of activating teams through coaching frameworks.

Participants discussed a wealth of concepts and frameworks, battle-tested in the trenches of activating teams toward climate initiatives. Familiar models like the GROW (goal, reality, options, and will; Whitmore, 1996) model and the solution-focused coaching model (see Grant, 2022) took center stage, creating a series of tried-and-tested methodologies. But an underlying issue began to surface: while these

frameworks proved effective in the realm of individual coaching, their utility within the complex systemic dynamics of sustainability and team change remained elusive.

Beyond the subjective views voiced on the Zoom call, broader research revealed a stark reality about the struggles organizations face in driving impactful climate action. Bain & Company's comprehensive survey and interviews involving 300 organizations uncovered a disheartening statistic: a staggering 98% of climate programs fail in organizations, with 81% deeming the applied frameworks and approaches to be of only moderate value (Davis-Peccoud, 2017).

The reasons behind this perceived inefficacy seem to stem from a range of factors, including the ability to form a robust business case, communications, and an inability to embed sustainability in the way the business runs on a day-to-day basis. The impact of this in many organizations is a culture that creates a misalignment between the personal motivations of individual employees and the organizational/team objectives related to sustainability. Many climate initiatives fail to create an emotional resonance or sense of deeper purpose that connects people's core values and intrinsic drives to the environmental goals being set. Without this internalized commitment from individuals, organizational climate efforts risk becoming merely compliance-driven box-ticking exercises devoid of passion, stamina, and what it takes to identify and drive through the changes required. Even employees who intellectually understand the importance of sustainability can remain unmotivated if the initiatives feel disconnected from their own "why" – the personal reasons that give an issue spiritual or existential significance. Furthermore, a lack of frameworks that firstly bridge the gap between personal concern and professional action and secondly that bridge team and organizational divides around shared purpose seemed to undermine climate initiatives. Differing motivations, perspectives, and accountabilities across levels created a dysfunctional siloed environment rather than an aligned collective force.

The consensus from this data emerged like an unwavering verdict: the prevailing approach by most organizations was failing to truly activate their human capital and tap into the intrinsic drivers required to power authentic, sustained climate action from the ground up. Clearly, a fundamentally new paradigm for engaging the human factor was desperately needed. This sobering diagnosis of ineffectiveness provided the platform for the novel solution proposed by this research.

In response, a compact but determined research interest group coalesced during the call. Based in the United Kingdom were Dr Alyson Whybrow, Tabitha Jayne, Jaime Blakeley-Glover, and Dr Jonathan Rhodes, with additional expertise contributed by Alan Taylor in Australia and Andy Miller from Canada. Their mission: to delve into the specifics of personal characteristics relevant to climate change, paving the way to construct a comprehensive method that other coaches could wield as a blueprint for their coaching endeavors.

As the group grappled with their first question – what aspects should be measured to gauge effectiveness? – the IDG framework stepped into the spotlight. This framework held the promise of offering a perspective on personal characteristics cru-

cial for climate change engagement. The second question, equally pivotal, revolved around identifying individuals who could serve as test pilots for the measurements and interventions crafted by the group.

As a segment of the research team set out on the journey to pinpoint willing organizations for their research, Jonathan, based at the University of Plymouth and co-founder of Imagery Coaching, adopted a distinctive strategy. He cast a wide net within his academic domain, advertising the project "Measuring Inner Development Goals" among his undergraduate and master's students. Isabelle Rochmankowsk, an astute undergraduate, eagerly joined forces with Jonathan, forming a dynamic partnership as they delved into uncharted territories, intent on deciphering how to measure skills and qualities for inner development.

Their goal centered around the construction of a robust assessment tool, a process that required collaboration with focus groups composed of individuals with extensive experience within organizational settings and as climate coaches.

Focus groups: Crafting a blueprint for Inner Development Goals assessment

The objective was clear: orchestrate open discussions through focus groups to curate a collection of items that could seamlessly integrate into any organization's toolkit. The goal was to create a robust evaluation mechanism for inner goals, underpinned by personal skills and qualities of the IDG framework. This, in turn, would catalyze meaningful climate dialogues and pave the way for proactive measures. Armed with the five originally identified dimensions – relationship to self, cognitive skills, caring for others and the world, social skills, and driving change – alongside the collection of 23 skills and qualities (Inner Development Goals, 2022), the research team convened two distinct focus groups.

In the first group, comprising six CEOs, the emphasis lay on leveraging their high-level perspectives to scrutinize and refine the five dimensions and their related sub-themes. Simultaneously, the second group, comprising five executive coaches external to the research team, brought a meticulous and specialized viewpoint to the table. Their collective mission, again to dissect each of the five dimensions including the associated 23 skills and qualities and map out how these could seamlessly interlace to form a comprehensive questionnaire. In this collaborative forum, the fusion of executive leadership wisdom and coaching acumen became the mixture in which the foundation for assessing IDGs took shape.

In the realm of research, one quickly learns that plans rarely unfold as anticipated. The journey of our focus groups, each conducted online with a duration of approximately 1.5 hours, was no exception. In the CEO focus group, a consensus swiftly emerged on the appropriateness of the identified five dimensions. However,

an astute observation highlighted a missing link: a gap in the IDG framework. In response, the CEOs introduced a sixth dimension named "organizational belonging". One CEO eloquently voiced the sentiment that the IDG framework "misses the link between the individual and their working environment, which is where the change is set to occur".

Meanwhile, the discussions within the executive coaching focus group unfolded independently, shielded from the insights of the CEOs. Surprisingly, the executive coaches delved into an additional dimension, labeling it "culture connection". Their focus encompassed crucial aspects such as "aligning personal values to the organization", "role clarity", and "feeling heard during team meetings".

Harnessing the wealth of insights gleaned from these distinct discussions, a separate group of students, not privy to the original focus group deliberations but using transcripts, embarked on the meticulous task of refining a set of questions. These questions were designed to align with the 23 skills and qualities identified in the original IDG framework (refer to Table 9.1, items 1–23). Additionally, an extra set of six questions (Table 9.1, items 24–29) was tailored to capture the essence of the newly introduced sixth dimension. This amalgamation of perspectives and dimensions culminated in the birth of the Inner Development Goals – Adapted (IDG-A) questionnaire. Much like the pioneers of the IDG framework, the research group embraced openness in science, freely sharing the scale to foster collaborative advancement in the field.

Table 9.1: Inner Development Goals – Adapted (IDG-A).

	Please circle one per row	**Strongly disagree**	**Disagree**	**Neutral**	**Agree**	**Strongly agree**
1	I am aware of my values and purpose and am committed to my goals.	1	2	3	4	5
2	I act with sincerity, honesty, and integrity.	1	2	3	4	5
3	I have a willingness to be vulnerable and embrace change and consistently develop.	1	2	3	4	5
4	I am reflective with my own thoughts, feelings, and desires.	1	2	3	4	5
5	I can live in the here and now, without judgment and in a state of open-ended presence.	1	2	3	4	5
6	I critically review others' views, evidence, and plans without bias.	1	2	3	4	5
7	I have an understanding of, and skills in, working with complex and systemic conditions and causalities.	1	2	3	4	5

Table 9.1 (continued)

Please circle one per row		Strongly disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly agree
8	I understand and actively make use of insights from differing perspectives.	1	2	3	4	5
9	I can make sense out of complex stories and patterns.	1	2	3	4	5
10	I have a long-term vision and can formulate goals and sustain commitment.	1	2	3	4	5
11	I relate to others and to the world with a basic sense of appreciation, gratitude, and joy.	1	2	3	4	5
12	I have a keen sense of being connected with and/or being a part of a larger whole, such as a community, humanity, or global ecosystem.	1	2	3	4	5
13	I act in accordance with the needs of the situation without concern for my own importance.	1	2	3	4	5
14	I relate to others, myself, and nature with kindness, empathy, and compassion and address related suffering.	1	2	3	4	5
15	I really listen to others to: foster genuine dialogue, manage conflicts constructively, and to adapt communication to suit diverse groups.	1	2	3	4	5
16	I motivate others and help facilitate collaborative relationships with diverse individuals, characterized by psychological safety and genuine co-creation.	1	2	3	4	5
17	I am willing and competent to embrace diversity and include people and collectives with different views and backgrounds.	1	2	3	4	5
18	I show trust, create, and maintain trusting relationships.	1	2	3	4	5
19	I inspire and mobilize others to engage in shared purposes.	1	2	3	4	5
20	I stand up for values, make decisions, take decisive action and, if need be, challenge and disrupt existing structures and views.	1	2	3	4	5
21	I generate and develop original ideas, innovate, and am willing to disrupt conventional patterns.	1	2	3	4	5

Table 9.1 (continued)

Please circle one per row		Strongly disagree	Disagree	Neutral	Agree	Strongly agree
22	I sustain and communicate a sense of hope, positive attitude, and confidence in the possibility of meaningful change.	1	2	3	4	5
23	I stay engaged and remain determined and patient even when efforts take a long time to bear fruit.	1	2	3	4	5
24	My values and goals align to my organizations' and teams'.	1	2	3	4	5
25	I have detailed role clarity, autonomy, and feel accountable.	1	2	3	4	5
26	Stressful situations are dealt with as a collective team and there is a culture of support, compassion, and learning.	1	2	3	4	5
27	It is easy to contribute and feel heard and valued in meetings.	1	2	3	4	5
28	Strategy is discussed and disseminated, and I have a sense of team belonging.	1	2	3	4	5
29	I contribute to the collective vision, have clear targets, and can track progress of myself and team.	1	2	3	4	5

Source: Reproduced with permission from the authors (Rhodes et al., 2023).

Subsequent to the formulation of the questionnaire, the research group proactively sought validation by sharing it with the two focus groups, inviting their critical assessment and feedback. The response was resoundingly positive, with both focus groups unanimously endorsing the suitability of the questionnaire, affirming that the instrument effectively assessed the skills and qualities crucial for individuals engaged in change initiatives. However, one potential issue raised was the possibility of self-reporting bias, where respondents may respond in a way that presents themselves in an overly positive light rather than being fully objective. To address this, the IDG-A employed three strategies. First, the phrasing of questions avoided leading or prescriptive language that could prime respondents. Additionally, the anonymity of responses was ensured to reduce socially desirable responding. Finally, before delivering the IDG-A we informed participants that the responses, although confidential, require honesty as scores will shape future research. With robustness a key focus, the next step was to test-drive the IDG-A in the field.

Test-driving the IDG-A and beyond

As the IDG-A was being shaped, the main portion of the research group had recruited four global organizations to test the measure. A pilot study, involving 39 participants, ranging from those highly engaged with climate issues to those more ambivalent, was conducted. Participants were chosen by the organizations (not the research team), selected based on their roles, which involved sustainability in some capacity. This pilot study served as a test-drive for the IDG-A. The participants, comprising 14 females and 25 males, with a mean age of 31 (SD = 10.5), completed the test twice, then had a debrief interview. The retest window was available a week after the initial test and remained open for six weeks. Initially, only seven respondents completed the questionnaire in time for their data to be included in the original publication, however, since then, a commendable 31 out of the original 39 participants have participated in the retest. To gauge the reliability of the IDG-A, a correlation score above 0.8 is considered strong, with a score of 1 indicating perfect reliability. Impressively, the reliability of the IDG-A stands at 0.89, signifying that the IDG-A questionnaire demonstrates strong reliability.

Moving forward, exploration extended to the six domains, aiming to unveil any potential relationships. The initial assumption was that each dimension possesses a unique quality, leading us to expect minimal, if any, significantly strong correlations. However, as is often the case when developing questionnaires, findings diverged from this expectation. Contrary to the initial hypothesis, most domains and the combined average score exhibited noteworthy relationships with each distinct domain. This intriguing revelation suggests that the total score serves as a robust indicator of inner development. It appears that the domains, far from being mutually exclusive, intricately link to one another, forming a cohesive framework that collectively contributes to the assessment of inner development.

Delving beyond the mere statistical relationships and probability values, the questionnaire's intriguing items unfolded as a catalyst for deep conversations about climate and personal growth. In debrief sessions with participants, the majority shared instances where the questions not only ignited engaging discussions with colleagues but also penetrated into essential topics such as values and communication. What materialized surpassed the boundaries of a conventional questionnaire; it organically morphed into an intervention. The IDG-A actively shaped dialogues and, in the process, evoked a profound inquisitiveness regarding individual motivations rooted in collective values within organizational contexts. During debrief conversations with participants, the outcome seemed to be an activation of teams through enhanced self-awareness, paving the way for more cohesive and purpose-driven collaboration.

Upon reflection, the research team recognized that they had acquired a significant measure of personal skills and qualities seamlessly intertwined with organizational actions. However, eight months into the project, a setback emerged with the departure of two crucial members who had played instrumental roles in shaping our

collective thinking – their absence attributed to workload and illness. This unforeseen turn of events entrusted the responsibility to Andy, Alan, Jaime, and Jonathan to navigate the final phase of the research. Their focus shifted towards investigating whether a meticulously designed climate intervention could not only influence the elevation of IDG scores but also trigger meaningful net-zero behaviors. This critical juncture refocused the team's unwavering determination to stretch the boundaries of their research and delve into the practical implications of their findings within the realms of climate action and individual well-being.

Adverts went out on social media platforms and phone calls were made in the hope to recruit participants for a small study investigating "measuring and training Inner Development Goals". In this buzzing arena of outreach, Sarah Miller's eyes caught wind of the advert, and a flicker of recognition danced across her thoughts: "Inner Development Goals . . . where have I heard that before?" she pondered. The answer lay within the recesses of her conference notes, a topic that had sparked her interest in a bygone event. Driven by her penchant for data, research, and empirically grounded interventions, she followed the link and swiftly coordinated a meeting with the research team.

Sarah Miller, known for her efficiency and aversion to time-wasting, prefers straight talk and direct answers. Her initial encounter was with Jaime, a seasoned professional with over two decades immersed in sustainability and ESG, possessing the adaptability to ensure Sarah felt heard and understood. In the first few minutes of their interaction, the alignment became apparent to Sarah – this was a project she envisioned within the corridors of her company.

With no time to spare, Sarah cut to the chase, questioning Jaime on the starting point. "Do we begin with our organizational goal?" she inquired. Jaime's response was a strategic redirection. "No," he asserted, "we commence with 'Why should you personally care?' We firmly believe that motivation, particularly intrinsic motivation, is the cornerstone for goal setting. Setting targets without individual buy-in, without understanding the 'why', turns the endeavor into an uphill battle." Music to Sarah's ears.

Sarah continued to question Jaime: "Okay, so you start with the why, then what happens next?"

"Imagery," Jaime responded.

Training Inner Development Goals

At the project's inception, our research team operated devoid of a specific method or framework; instead, the research group navigated through a cacophony of ideas, theories, and a diverse array of approaches each team member brought to the table. Amidst this noise, a foundational belief emerged: they wouldn't focus on teaching methods to achieve net-zero. The stumbling block, as people often express, lies not in

the lack of knowledge but in the motivation to act. It's akin to understanding the importance of daily fruit and vegetable intake for health or committing to 30 minutes of daily exercise: knowledge exists, action falters. In tune with two of the IDG domains – relationship to self and cognitive skills – they aimed to commence with personal meaning. This commenced discussions surrounding personal values, fostering self-awareness. Simultaneously, they delved into cognitive skills through the exploration and coaching of imagery, an immersive experience that you are invited to trial now.

Wherever you find yourself, take a moment to pause. In the theater of your mind, in a moment we are going to ask you to transport yourself into the future as if a time machine has been unveiled and you've harnessed its power for time travel. So, let's propel ourselves 25 years into the future. Before you embark on this mental journey, allow us to provide some scaffolding.

Imagine this: goals have been achieved, climate pledges have been steadfastly kept, and the clean air resonates with motivation evident in the vibrant ambiance surrounding you. Achievement manifests in conversations and expressions. Even the wildlife contributes to the melody of a thriving environment. This is the optimistic future, one that you and others have diligently worked towards.

Take a moment to immerse yourself in this imagined scene – layering the sounds, the scents, sensations of the air, the visual elements, how you move, and how you feel being in this vivid landscape.

Such positive imagery is a rarity in our mental repertoire, often overshadowed by bleak narratives and tales of impending doom. Attempts to think positively frequently revert to negative probabilities, limiting the expansiveness of our imagination, a crucial cognitive skill to solving any challenge. Consequently, the training of our thought processes must be personalized and anchored in positive outcomes.

But why does this personalization matter? Its significance lies in aligning an issue with individual emotions, values, and behaviors, thereby transforming change from a mere aspiration into an essential imperative. At the core of our approach lies the articulation of a crystal-clear message: Why is this important to me? In a quest for meaning, the research team painstakingly crafted a well-defined program, seamlessly weaving together personal emotions, values, mindsets, attitudes, cognitions, and behaviors. This detailed flow, a choreography aptly termed the meaning, awareness, and purpose (MAP) model, endeavors to reveal the interconnected layers propelling meaningful change that links you to your team and your organization.

Partnering with two major corporations grappling with motivational challenges akin to those faced by Sarah Miller, she watched our study unfold, eager for her company to start the project if the results suited her needs. Using the IDG-A, baseline scores were assessed, and no discernible differences were discovered between the organizations, highlighting the similarities in their employees' skills and qualities.

To test the MAP model, a control group organization was needed, who would receive the well-known and highly successful approach of carbon literacy training, while the other received the MAP model. Carbon literacy training lasted for 15 hours

over 10 weeks, dissecting strategies for climate action and resulted in an organizational project. On the other hand, the MAP group, which had a total of 9 hours over 10 weeks, delved into intrinsic motivation headed by Andy and Jaime, explored imaginative solutions for change with Jonathan, and triggered a shift towards purpose (How do my actions impact others?), aligned with the IDG framework domains: caring for others and the world, social skills, and enabling change.

While the carbon literacy training group received a conventional top-down approach with goals set by leadership, the MAP group took an employee-driven path. Forming this group proved challenging initially, as individual participants arrived with widely varying levels of motivation, personal meanings attached to climate change, and comfort exploring inner drivers. Some were highly passionate environmental activists, while others were relatively disconnected from the issue. Through the early MAP workshops on self-discovery and visioning, these divergent individual "MAPs" initially occurred as conflicts and barriers to team-wide cohesion. Vocal activists could come across as preachy, while the disengaged seemed apathetic. However, as the group delved deeper into mutual understanding, perspective taking, and caring for each other's journeys, a team MAP emerged organically.

The diverse composition – a microcosm of the broader organizational workforce – became a strength rather than an obstacle. Safety was built for the disengaged to become curious, and the activists learned to inspire through listening. Collectively, they crafted an authentic, employee-led sustainability goal that resonated personally while promoting the new organizational belonging dimension. Specific systems thinking workshops under the guidance of Alan and Jaime enabled this group to turn their individual epiphanies into real-world projects and accountability partnerships across differences. A common "language" took root, fueled by renewed openness to others' experiences. While conflicts still arose, the team's shared investment in crafting and sharing their goal created a cascading effect, with the blueprint of the journey shown on Figure 9.1. The MAP model shows the coaching process which progresses from discussing individual meaning through to personal action, then on to team meaning and team action. After one cycle, the individual and the team operate together, thus making the numbers and direction of the process moot.

In contrast, carbon literacy participants reported gaining valuable climate education, but often perceived it as an obligatory exercise divorced from their inner world. Some found the MAP model's self-work more uncomfortable initially but described it as catalyzing deeper personal breakthroughs. The contrasting outcomes highlighted the power of the MAP model for activating teams in a grassroots way – bridging individual inner work to collective outer impact.

In a surprising twist, IDG-A scores soared in the MAP group whilst the carbon literacy training group remained static, showing a significant difference between the two groups – a resounding testament to the impact of personal inner development within the realm of climate coaching.

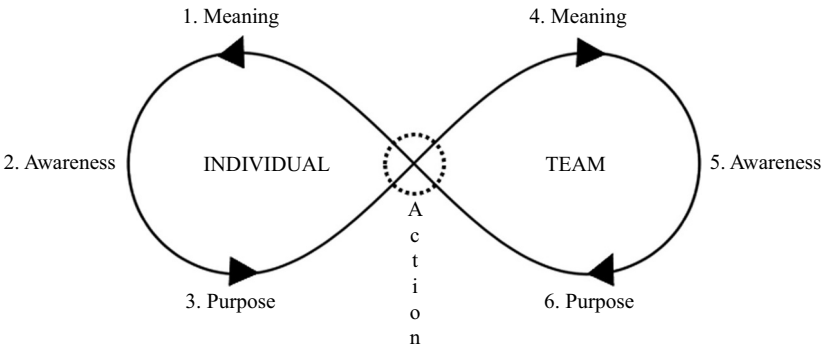

Figure 9.1: The MAP model. Source: Reproduced with permission from the authors (Rhodes et al., 2023).

As the results trickled in, Sarah Miller eagerly delved into the findings, keen to uncover the impact on the two organizations. Her expectations ran high, tempered only by a touch of cautious optimism. The question lingered: Could this research, even if it successfully activated other teams and organizations and improved inner development, evoke a similar response from hers?

To her delight, the results didn't just meet but exceeded her expectations.

Two months later, Sarah's team underwent the MAP model intervention and exhibited a remarkable change. Energized by the process, the team seamlessly transitioned from theoretical understanding to practical application. Encouraged by the newfound clarity on personal values and motivations, they initiated a small-scale climate action project within the organization. This initial endeavor not only bolstered their confidence but also served as a catalyst for broader engagement.

The success of this additional project laid the foundation for more ambitious ventures. Empowered by the MAP model, Sarah's team formulated a series of net-zero goals that intricately connected personal targets, team aspirations, and community initiatives. The collaborative spirit fostered by the MAP intervention not only propelled the team towards their climate action goals but also fostered a sense of shared purpose and togetherness. What began as a tentative exploration had evolved into a robust framework guiding Sarah's team towards meaningful contributions to both organizational and environmental well-being.

Beyond the research

This research has sparked extensive global discussions among government and business leaders across diverse industries and sectors. While we cannot disclose the names of specific organizations, the IDG-A measure has been downloaded and utilized thousands of times by entities around the world, indicating its widespread adoption and appeal.

Some broader trends have emerged: the approach seems to resonate particularly well in larger, multinational organizations with globally distributed workforces and operations. The challenges of aligning employee mindsets and channeling passionate but scattered sustainability efforts into cohesive action appear magnified in these complex environments. The MAP model has proven valuable in these situations for unifying disconnected "green champions" under a shared purpose and vision.

Interestingly, the framework has also gained traction in more hierarchical, traditional industries like manufacturing, energy, and natural resources extraction. Here, the ability to inspire grassroots-level commitment to environmental goals, rather than mere top-down compliance, has been a key driver of adoption. Regardless of industry, size, or structure, organizations seem to gravitate towards the IDG-A and MAP model when seeking human-centric solutions – tools that tap into the innate psychological and emotional drivers required to fully activate their workforces as agents of sustainability and positive climate impact.

For Sarah Miller, who has left her ESG role and is now a CEO, this journey has taken on a personal passion, and the solutions generated have proven to be innovative. In her current team, she is actively engaged in the pursuit of sustainable goals and shared leadership, effectively bridging the gap between individual awareness, collective team action, and global sustainability goals.

The impact of this research, shaped by a handful of coaches with diverse backgrounds, extends beyond coaching boundaries and has fundamental implications for how organizations approach climate and sustainability. The research calls into question the accepted wisdom that the path to catalyze employee action on these critical issues is more technical training and information. It points to the need for wider skill sets for sustainability leaders and an expanded role for human development professionals. Sarah Miller didn't need more information to layer on top of what she already knew. She needed a more human-centric approach, one that helped her connect with the power of her and her team's "why" and feel part of a community committed to change. It was only by unlocking the potential of this "latent" motivation that she could truly start to embed sustainability in the DNA of the organization and bring about the human-centric change required to shift business as usual.

These coaches initially connected through the CCA, a charitable organization dedicated to supporting coaches and psychologists involved in climate change initiatives within organizations. Following this research, we've conducted workshops hosted by the CCA, participated in national and international conferences, and worked diligently to elevate the profile of our findings, further administering the IDG-A and MAP to industry leaders globally. However, we must remain cognizant that the neoliberal paradigm pervading modern capitalist societies could influence the positive impacts observed. The prioritization of profit motives, market competitiveness and individualism intrinsic to neoliberalism may drive sustainability efforts into reputation management and greenwashing rhetoric rather than genuine organizational change. Nurturing personal meaning and human connectedness, as the IDG-A and MAP model advocate,

could inadvertently reinforce consumerist and self-actualization narratives that paradoxically drive unsustainable overconsumption. Nurturing a "why" that places the health of our planet at the heart of any intervention has to be a non-negotiable. To counterbalance such insidious undercurrents, we are actively expanding our approach as a team and in our own networks.

Jaime is spearheading the development of the Most Sustainable Workplace Index (MSWI) measure, already administered to thousands of employees worldwide. This tool assesses the degree to which sustainability is intrinsically embedded into an organization's culture and decision-making processes beyond just the level of individual employees. Initial results accurately indicate where the motivational gap exists in organizations, and therefore where to focus time and effort in promoting sustainability action.

Meanwhile, Jonathan is playing a dual role: supporting cutting-edge net-zero research projects in collaboration with the University of Plymouth, while also translating the lessons from the IDG-A and MAP model into innovative coaching practices. On the research front, a key focus is on building self-awareness and leveraging the power of motivational imagery through an approach called functional imagery training. This research has shown to be five times more effective than traditional methods at motivating individuals when working towards challenging goals. Complementing the research is Jonathan's work at Imagery Coaching, the consultancy he runs with US-based business partner Joanna Grover, integrating scientific inquiry with cutting-edge applied coaching practices. Here, they deliver unique coaching (and courses) that break the status quo by formally assessing clients' motivations, imagery and imagination capacities. This reveals unique insights that allow them to refine personal and team performance, while developing tailor-made frameworks for operationalizing the identified opportunities.

Alan, based in Australia, is developing comprehensive coaching packages centered around utilizing the MAP model, combined with systems thinking principles, to equip organizations and communities with strategies for sustainable transformation. And Andy, operating out of Canada, is actively working alongside diverse communities to co-create localized approaches that amalgamate the IDG-A/MAP model with indigenous wisdom and cultural perspectives to reach net-zero targets in a holistic, inclusive manner.

Conclusion

Ultimately, what our findings reinforce is the indispensable role of fostering genuine interpersonal connection, shared commitment to a mutual higher purpose, and institutionalizing sustainability as a collective way of being rather than just an extrinsic obligation – teams create sustainability norms. While challenging prevalent paradigms, this pathway

highlights how global issues can overcome being perceived as remote, instead becoming deeply relatable and intrinsically motivating for both individuals and organizations alike. Holistically integrating the intrapersonal, interpersonal, and cultural dimensions, our expanded work strives to catalyze transformative change that is authentically embraced and collectively reinforced from the inside out – igniting a dynamic force that can propel consistent, impactful climate action that endures.

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